

Trust Deficits and Platform Unreliability in Nigeria's E-Government: Evidence from a Survey-Based Analysis of Citizen Satisfaction

Successive government in Nigeria have always been expressly ambitious about digitizing its operations and services and reducing the need for paper. This ambition is embodied in several policies, including the National Digital Economy Policy and Strategy (NDEPS 2020–2030) and the National e-Government Interoperability Framework (Ne-GIF), FCSSIP 2021–2025 amongst others. These policies carry a common objective of transforming the public service through digitization. Unfortunately, the lived experiences of the citizens and public servants tell a different story, exposing the gap between the policy ambitions and digital realities. Using primary data collected from 215 E-government service users, this study computed multiple OLS regression and descriptive statistics to discover empirically examine how trust deficits and platform unreliability influence citizen satisfaction with e-government services. Results revealed that that only 43.7% of respondents trust the security of their online operations ($M = 3.30$, $SD = 0.90$), while only 23% agreed that the platforms are stable ($M = 2.70$, $SD = 1.00$). Regression analysis (Adj. $R^2 = 0.432$) reveals that efficiency ($\beta = 0.418$, $p < .001$), trust in security ($\beta = 0.196$, $p < .001$), user-friendliness ($\beta = 0.166$, $p < .01$), and complaint resolution ($\beta = 0.164$, $p < .01$) are the strongest predictors of citizen satisfaction. These findings are aligned with the Afrobarometer Round 10 (2024, $N = 1,600$), which reported high level of institutional distrust in e-government services. Drawing on the empirical findings, this study proposes a six-point reform framework which addresses trust, platform reliability, infrastructure constraints, corruption risks and institutional capacity deficits in Nigeria's e-government system, with broader applicability within Sub-Saharan Africa.

Keywords: *e-government, digital trust, platform instability, Nigeria, ICT policy, innovation systems, Africa*

1. Introduction

The promise of e-government, which involves the use of information and communications technology (ICT) to deliver public services, improve administrative efficiency, and deepen civic participation has become a central pillar of development discourse across Sub-Saharan Africa. In Nigeria, this ambition is enshrined in the NDEPS 2020–2030, the Strategic Roadmap and Action Plan 2.0 (SRAP 2.0), and the Ne-GIF, setting out a bold vision of a citizen-centred, paperless government aligned with the African Union's Agenda 2063 and the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Yet the distance between policy aspiration and reality remains vast. Citizens who engage with government digital platforms routinely encounter crashing portals, slow servers, opaque complaint channels, and mounting concerns about data security experiences that erode the institutional trust foundational to democratic governance. The scale of this challenge is corroborated by the Afrobarometer Round 10 survey of 1,600 Nigerian adults (2024): only 47.0% expressed trust in the Presidency, 49.0% in the National Assembly, and 47.9% in the courts meaning a majority distrust all three central state institutions (Afrobarometer, 2024). Against this backdrop, building citizen confidence in government digital platforms is doubly formidable.

This paper investigates these dynamics empirically, asking: which service quality dimensions most significantly predict citizen satisfaction with e-government in Nigeria? What structural and systemic barriers sustain trust deficits and platform instability? And what does this evidence imply for digital governance reform? The paper makes three original contributions: it provides quantitative empirical grounding for arguments about e-government trust in an African context; it disaggregates trust perceptions by gender and age; and it frames Nigeria's e-government challenges within the national innovation systems (NIS) literature, arguing that platform instability is a symptom of systemic innovation failure.

2. Literature Review

2.1 E-Government and Digital Public Service Delivery in Africa

E-government scholarship has evolved from techno-determinist accounts of ICT deployment to nuanced analyses of adoption behaviour, governance dynamics, and sociotechnical complexity (Heeks, 2006; Weerakkody et al., 2013). In the African context, scholars have highlighted the 'design-reality gap' (Heeks, 2003) the mismatch between system design assumptions and the realities of implementation in low-income governance environments — manifesting in infrastructure deficits, human capacity constraints, and institutional fragility. Nigeria's trajectory illustrates these tensions acutely: despite successive policy frameworks from the NITDA Act 2007 to NDEPS 2020–2030, assessments consistently identify progressive strategy alongside fragmented delivery (Alatise & Musa, 2018; Ndukwe, 2019).

2.2 Trust as a Foundational Dimension of E-Government Adoption

Trust is widely established as a prerequisite for digital public service adoption (Welch et al., 2005; Beldad et al., 2010). Citizens must trust the technology, the service provider, and the broader governance system before willingly submitting personal data or relying on digitally

generated documents. Twizeyimana and Andersson (2019) argue that trust must be earned through consistent service delivery and responsive complaint resolution not assumed through policy mandates. The Afrobarometer Round 10 data (2024) illustrate the scale of the challenge: 82.3% rated government service delivery performance as poor, 88.2% gave the same verdict on corruption control, and 54.1% disagreed that officials explain their actions (Afrobarometer, 2024). This is the trust environment into which Nigeria's e-government platforms are being introduced.

2.3 Platform Reliability, Infrastructure, and Innovation Systems

Beyond trust, platform reliability and ease of use are established as key determinants of e-government satisfaction (DeLone & McLean, 2003; Venkatesh et al., 2003). Platform instability generates 'digital frustration', eroding motivation and deepening disengagement (Alomari et al., 2012). The Afrobarometer Round 10 survey (2024) found that only 42.6% of Nigerian adults have mobile internet access — with a stark 54.4% urban vs. 33.3% rural divide and 38.3% have never used the internet at all (Afrobarometer, 2024). A structural precondition failure of this magnitude cannot be resolved by any amount of platform optimisation alone.

The national innovation systems (NIS) framework (Freeman, 1987; Lundvall, 1992; Nelson, 1993) contextualises these challenges beyond individual user behaviour. Effective digital governance requires institutional, organisational, and social infrastructure to support continuous improvement. Afrobarometer Round 10 data (2024) confirm the systemic dimension: 92.9% of Nigerians rated government performance on economic management as poor, 94.2% on job creation, and 91.2% on electricity provision. Addressing Nigeria's e-government deficits therefore requires the developmental, political economy-sensitive approach that the African innovation systems literature prescribes (Lall, 2004; Pietrobelli & Rabellotti, 2011).

3. Research Methodology

3.1 Research Design and Sampling

This study adopts a quantitative-dominant cross-sectional survey design. Primary data were collected via a structured, self-administered online questionnaire with six modules: (i) demographic profile; (ii) e-service usage history; (iii) ICT policy awareness; (iv) a thirteen-item Likert-scale battery of service quality constructs; (v) systemic and structural barriers; and (vi) open-ended items. All Likert items used a five-point scale (1 = Strongly Disagree to 5 = Strongly Agree).

The study targets Nigerian citizens with direct e-government experience, a population not enumerated in any accessible national registry. Purposive sampling with snowball diffusion was adopted (Creswell, 2014; Patton, 2015; Etikan et al., 2016), with the questionnaire distributed via email, LinkedIn, and WhatsApp professional channels. A total of 218 responses were collected (9 September–12 October 2025); three incomplete entries were removed, yielding a final sample of $N = 215$. This exceeds the 200-case threshold for Likert-scale research (Hair et al., 2010) and meets the ≥ 10 observations-per-predictor rule for multiple regression (Field, 2018). Tables 1 and 2 present sampling parameters and demographic profile.

Table 1
Sampling Design Summary

Criterion	Details
Target population	Nigerian citizens with direct e-government platform experience; no accessible sampling frame exists
Sampling technique	Purposive sampling with snowball diffusion (multi-channel online distribution)
Sample size	N = 215 valid responses (218 collected; 3 removed as incomplete)
Data collection period	9 September 2025 – 12 October 2025 (17 active days over 33-day window)
Instrument	Structured online questionnaire (Google Forms): 6 modules, 13-item Likert battery
Limitations	Non-probability design; over-represents educated/employed Nigerians; findings are analytically rather than statistically generalisable

Note. Survey instrument available from the authors on request.

Table 2
Demographic Profile of Survey Respondents (N = 215)

Variable	Category	n	%
Gender	Male	125	58.1%
	Female	90	41.9%
Age group	21–30	29	13.5%
	31–40	63	29.3%
	41–50	89	41.4%
	51–60	27	12.6%
Education	Bachelor's degree	86	40.0%
	Post-graduate	126	58.6%
Employment	Employed (formal)	155	72.1%
	Self-employed	48	22.3%
E-service use	Has used e-government platform	193	89.8%
	Has never used	22	10.2%

Note. Percentages may not sum to 100% due to rounding.

3.2 Analytical Framework

Descriptive statistics (means, standard deviations, frequency distributions) were computed for all Likert-scale items. Three multiple OLS regression models were estimated to identify

independent predictors of: (i) citizen satisfaction; (ii) trust in security; and (iii) willingness to recommend e-services. Predictor selection was theory driven. Multicollinearity was assessed through bivariate correlations; no predictor pair exceeded $r = .62$, well below the threshold of concern ($r > .80$; Field, 2018). Listwise deletion yielded 210–211 complete cases per model. All computations were performed in Python 3.

4. Empirical Findings

4.1 E-Service Adoption and Usage Patterns

A substantial majority (193/215, 89.8%) report having used at least one Nigerian government e-service platform. The most widely cited include NIMC/NIN (106 respondents), BuyPower electricity payment (39), the Nigeria Immigration Service passport system (37), the Corporate Affairs Commission (32), and the FRSC (25). Usage intensity is notably low: 29.3% used only one e-service in the preceding 12 months, 23.3% two, and only 12.1% five or more. This episodic engagement pattern — driven by bureaucratic necessity rather than digital routine — is itself a manifestation of the quality deficits documented below.

4.2 Descriptive Analysis of Platform Quality

Table 3 presents descriptive statistics for all thirteen service quality dimensions. Respondents hold moderately positive perceptions of e-government's potential advantages while expressing substantial scepticism about actual reliability, security, and complaint responsiveness.

Table 3

Descriptive Statistics: E-Government Service Quality Dimensions (N = 212–213)

Service Quality Statement	M	SD	% Agree+	% Disagree–	n
TRUST & SECURITY					
I trust the security of information I submit online	3.30	0.90	43.7%	19.7%	213
I believe documents generated are legitimate and reliable	3.53	0.76	61.0%	10.3%	213
PLATFORM RELIABILITY					
The platforms are stable and rarely crash	2.70	1.00	23.0%	47.4%	213
Complaints via digital platforms are resolved timely	2.88	1.05	31.6%	38.2%	212
SERVICE EFFECTIVENESS					
Online services are faster than manual processes	3.53	1.50	70.4%	24.9%	213
E-services reduce the need to visit physical offices	3.61	1.24	73.6%	25.5%	212
I can complete transactions online without assistance	3.43	1.07	57.5%	19.8%	212
Digital platforms help reduce bribery and middlemen	3.56	1.01	65.7%	20.7%	213

USER EXPERIENCE & SATISFACTION					
The interfaces of government websites are user-friendly	3.31	0.93	52.6%	18.3%	213
Overall, I find government e-services efficient	3.44	0.91	55.7%	16.0%	212
I am satisfied with my experience using e-platforms	3.33	0.89	50.2%	19.2%	213
CITIZEN OUTLOOK					
I would recommend e-services to others	3.85	0.79	76.4%	5.2%	212
I believe government e-services will continue to improve	3.94	0.88	84.4%	6.1%	212

Note. *M* = mean on 5-point scale (1 = Strongly Disagree; 5 = Strongly Agree). Agree+ = Agree or Strongly Agree. Disagree− = Disagree or Strongly Disagree.

Platform stability registers the lowest mean ($M = 2.70$, $SD = 1.00$), with 47.4% actively disagreeing. Complaint resolution records the second-lowest ($M = 2.88$, $SD = 1.05$; 38.2% negative). Trust in security scores $M = 3.30$ ($SD = 0.90$) with 43.7% positive — meaning a majority do not affirm that their data is secure. In stark contrast, citizen outlook items score markedly higher: belief in future improvement ($M = 3.94$; 84.4%) and willingness to recommend ($M = 3.85$; 76.4%). This divergence between current quality experience and future optimism — the paradox of optimism — is theoretically important and explored in Section 5.3.

4.3 Regression Analysis

Model 1: Predictors of Citizen Satisfaction

Table 4 reports OLS regression results with citizen satisfaction as the dependent variable ($R^2 = 0.451$; Adj. $R^2 = 0.432$; $F(7, 203) = 23.8$, $p < .001$).

Table 4

OLS Regression: Predictors of Citizen Satisfaction with E-Government

Predictor Variable	B	SE	t	p
(Constant)	0.417	0.305	1.369	ns
Trust in security	0.196	0.059	3.340	< .001 ***
Platform stability	0.017	0.054	0.317	ns
Complaint resolution	0.164	0.051	3.212	< .01 **
User-friendliness	0.166	0.051	3.283	< .01 **
Anti-corruption belief	−0.019	0.045	−0.433	ns
Perceived speed	−0.051	0.033	−1.534	ns
Overall efficiency	0.418	0.058	7.187	< .001 ***

$$R^2 = 0.451 \mid \text{Adj. } R^2 = 0.432 \mid F(7, 203) = 23.8, p < .001 \mid N = 211$$

Note. *B* = unstandardised coefficient; *SE* = standard error; *ns* = not significant at $p < .05$. *** $p < .001$; ** $p < .01$.

Overall efficiency is the strongest independent predictor ($\beta = 0.418$, $t = 7.187$, $p < .001$). Trust in security is the second strongest ($\beta = 0.196$, $p < .001$), establishing data security confidence as an independent contributor even after controlling for platform quality. User-friendliness ($\beta = 0.166$, $p < .01$) and complaint resolution ($\beta = 0.164$, $p < .01$) are both independently significant. The four significant predictors including efficiency, trust, user-friendliness, and complaint resolution are precisely the dimensions on which Nigeria's platforms perform most poorly.

Model 2: Predictors of Trust in Security

Table 5 examines what platform quality dimensions independently predict trust in security (Adj. $R^2 = 0.210$; $F(6, 204) = 10.3$, $p < .001$).

Table 5

OLS Regression: Predictors of Trust in Security

Predictor Variable	B	SE	t	p
(Constant)	1.192	0.355	3.359	< .001 ***
Platform stability	0.142	0.063	2.261	< .05 *
Complaint resolution	0.045	0.061	0.743	ns
User-friendliness	-0.024	0.067	-0.359	ns
Anti-corruption belief	-0.071	0.053	-1.336	ns
Document legitimacy	0.127	0.071	1.772	.078
Overall efficiency	0.431	0.062	6.943	< .001 ***
$R^2 = 0.233 \mid \text{Adj. } R^2 = 0.210 \mid F(6, 204) = 10.3, p < .001 \mid N = 211$				

Note. *B* = unstandardised coefficient; *SE* = standard error; *ns* = not significant at $p < .05$. *** $p < .001$; * $p < .05$.

Overall efficiency again dominates ($\beta = 0.431$, $p < .001$): citizens infer unobservable data security from observable efficiency signals. Platform stability is the only other significant predictor ($\beta = 0.142$, $p < .05$), confirming that reliable platforms generate greater security confidence.

Model 3: Predictors of Willingness to Recommend

Table 6 examines what drives willingness to recommend e-government services — a critical measure for viral adoption (Adj. $R^2 = 0.226$; $F(5, 204) = 13.2$, $p < .001$).

Table 6*OLS Regression: Predictors of Willingness to Recommend E-Services*

Predictor Variable	B	SE	t	p
(Constant)	2.093	0.342	6.122	< .001 ***
Trust in security	0.087	0.063	1.394	ns
Citizen satisfaction	0.296	0.070	4.236	< .001 ***
Overall efficiency	0.115	0.070	1.645	.102
Belief in future improvement	0.044	0.056	0.772	ns
Perceived speed	-0.023	0.033	-0.700	ns
$R^2 = 0.245$ $Adj. R^2 = 0.226$ $F(5, 204) = 13.2$, $p < .001$ $N = 210$				

Note. B = unstandardised coefficient; SE = standard error; ns = not significant at $p < .05$. *** $p < .001$.

Citizen satisfaction is the sole independent predictor ($\beta = 0.296$, $p < .001$). This positions satisfaction as the critical gateway in the e-government adoption chain: it is the cumulative service experience — not any single quality dimension, trust, or optimism — that determines whether citizens become advocates.

4.4 Structural and Systemic Barriers

Table 7 summarises systemic barriers identified by respondents.

Table 7*Systemic and Structural Barriers to E-Service Adoption (N = 215)*

Barrier Category	n	% of Sample	Rank
Network / internet connectivity (primary obstacle)	102	47.4%	Primary obstacle
Corruption	62	28.8%	1st (structural)
Infrastructure deficit	48	22.3%	2nd (structural)
Policy enforcement gaps	36	16.7%	3rd (structural)
Staff / human capacity	22	10.2%	4th (structural)

Note. Categories are not mutually exclusive. Internet connectivity was assessed via a separate questionnaire item.

Network connectivity is the primary obstacle (47.4%), corroborated by Afrobarometer Round 10 (2024) data showing only 42.6% of Nigerian adults have mobile internet access. Corruption dominates structural barriers (28.8%), with open-ended responses revealing rent-seeking migrating into digital channels: *'Some of these processes are not 100% e-service, such that*

some personnel still feel that without parting with some money, your service won't be delivered or will be delayed' (Female, 31–40, Post-Graduate, Employed). The Afrobarometer Round 10 data (2024) confirm this at scale: 72.0% of Nigerian adults agree government officials are corrupt, 71.8% that the police are corrupt, and 63.8% that corruption is getting worse. On policy awareness, 59.1% of respondents know Nigeria's key e-governance frameworks (NDEPS, SRAP 2.0, Ne-GIF), while 40.9% remain unaware — underscoring both a communication deficit and the critical link between policy transparency and trust.

5. Analysis and Discussion

5.1 The Trust-Reliability Feedback Loop

The empirical findings reveal a reinforcing dynamic this paper terms the trust-reliability feedback loop. When platforms crash, transactions fail, and complaints go unresolved, citizens accumulate evidence that the digital state is unreliable. This reliability failure generalises into broader institutional mistrust, depressing engagement and reducing citizen feedback — allowing performance problems to persist undetected. The cycle then continues. This dynamic operates within a deeper context of generalised institutional distrust confirmed by Afrobarometer Round 10 (2024): 52.2% distrust the Presidency, 50.6% the National Assembly, and 51.6% the courts. Citizens approach government digital platforms with an a priori scepticism that platform failures rapidly confirm. The regression evidence supports this interpretation: trust in security independently predicts satisfaction ($\beta = 0.196$, $p < .001$); satisfaction is the sole predictor of recommendation behaviour ($\beta = 0.296$, $p < .001$); and platform stability independently predicts trust ($\beta = 0.142$, $p < .05$). The structural pathway is clear: unreliable platforms generate complaints; poor complaint resolution compounds dissatisfaction; dissatisfaction erodes trust; and low trust suppresses both adoption and advocacy.

5.2 Efficiency as the Primary Signal of Trust

The dominance of overall efficiency as a predictor of trust in security ($\beta = 0.431$, $p < .001$) is explicable through heuristic processing theory: data security is inherently unobservable. Citizens cannot inspect whether their NIN data is securely stored or their FIRS payment record encrypted. In the absence of direct observability, citizens use observable quality signals — particularly whether the system works reliably — as proxies for unobservable security attributes (McKnight et al., 2002). The policy implication is important: the most effective trust-building investment is not a data protection communications campaign but the visible delivery of efficient, reliable services. When government platforms work well, citizens trust them more broadly; when they fail as they currently do at high frequency, security trust suffers accordingly.

5.3 The Paradox of Optimism

The coexistence of platform quality dissatisfaction with high future optimism: 84.4% believing services will improve, 76.4% willing to recommend constitutes the paradox of optimism. It is partly explicable through reference baseline effects: citizens comparing imperfect digital services against manual processes characterised by queuing, bribery, and geographic barriers.

The 70.4% who agree e-services are faster and the 73.6% who agree they reduce office visits suggest that e-government clears a low but meaningful bar. However, satisfaction, not optimism, drives recommendation behaviour, and only 50.2% are currently satisfied. The optimism reading represents latent citizen goodwill that is at genuine risk if visible improvements are not forthcoming. Policymakers have a narrow window to convert this goodwill into sustained engagement.

5.4 Corruption Migration and the Limits of Technical Solutions

The finding that corruption is the most frequently cited structural barrier (28.8%) challenges the techno-optimist assumption that digitalisation will automatically reduce corruption. Citizens perceive e-government as having displaced corruption rather than eliminated it with rent-seeking behaviours migrating into digital channels. Afrobarometer Round 10 (2024) confirms the national scale: 72.0% agree government officials are corrupt and 63.8% believe corruption is getting worse, notwithstanding a decade of anti-corruption frameworks. Notably, 51.9% perceived presidential-level corruption as less severe than previously (Afrobarometer, 2024), suggesting domain-specific progress at the apex, even as bureaucratic corruption persists. Corruption in the Nigerian public sector is embedded in organisational cultures and incentive structures that do not disappear when a service moves online; reform strategies premised solely on removing human intermediaries are therefore insufficient.

5.5 Innovation Systems Perspective

From the NIS perspective, the findings are consistent with systemic innovation failure. The co-occurrence of infrastructure deficits, human capacity constraints, governance pathologies, and policy-implementation gaps confirms that Nigeria's e-government challenges cannot be resolved by optimising individual platforms in isolation. Afrobarometer Round 10 (2024) underlines the systemic dimension: 92.9% rated government performance on economic management as poor, 94.2% on job creation, 91.2% on electricity provision. Furthermore, 76.0% of respondents felt the government needs to do more to regulate the internet, while 98.4% believed it was likely to shut down internet access (Afrobarometer, 2024), signalling a parallel fear of authoritarian digital control that further complicates e-government adoption. Addressing these systemic failures requires the combination of strategic public investment, institutional capacity-building, and regulatory coherence that underlies effective innovation systems in any domain (Lall, 2004; Pietrobelli & Rabellotti, 2011).

6. Policy Recommendations

The findings yield six targeted recommendations for the Federal Ministry of Communications, Innovation and Digital Economy, NITDA, and relevant service delivery agencies.

6.1 Mandate Platform Reliability Through Service Level Agreements

With only 23.0% affirming platform stability, the government must establish legally enforceable Service Level Agreements (SLAs) specifying minimum uptime requirements, maximum transaction failure rates, and mandated incident response timelines. An independent monitoring body analogous to the Nigerian Communications Commission should impose

graduated sanctions for non-compliance and publish performance metrics accessible to citizens.

6.2 Build a Digital Trust Architecture Anchored in Visible Service Delivery

Since trust is primarily a signal of perceived efficiency, the most impactful trust-building investment is consistent, visible service delivery. In parallel, government should accelerate implementation of the Nigeria Data Protection Act 2023 at platform level: mandatory privacy notices, 72-hour data breach notifications, Data Protection Compliance Officers for major agencies, and a citizen-facing dashboard showing how personal data is used across government platforms.

6.3 Rebuild the Complaint Resolution Infrastructure

Complaint resolution is independently significant in the satisfaction model ($\beta = 0.164$, $p < .01$) yet among the weakest-performing dimensions ($M = 2.88$; only 31.6% positive). Government must invest in real-time complaint tracking visible to citizens, mandated 48-hour resolution timelines, and escalation pathways not requiring reversion to offline channels. Independent civil society monitoring, with annual public reporting, should be formally institutionalised.

6.4 Treat Internet Connectivity as a Non-Negotiable Prerequisite

Network connectivity is the single most cited adoption barrier (47.4%). Afrobarometer Round 10 (2024) confirms only 42.6% of Nigerian adults have mobile internet access, with a 21-percentage-

point urban–rural gap and 38.3% having never used the internet. Coordinated, time-bound investment in last-mile connectivity — particularly in underserved northern and rural communities — must be treated as a precondition for e-government adoption. National Broadband Plan targets and the Universal Service Provision Fund should be subject to legislative audit.

6.5 Implement Anti-Corruption Architecture Within Digital Channels

Corruption migration requires anti-corruption interventions specifically designed for digital environments: mandatory end-to-end transaction audit trails accessible to the ICPC and EFCC; randomised algorithmic auditing of platform transactions; removal of human discretion from as many service steps as technically feasible; and protected whistleblower reporting mechanisms built into all major government platforms.

6.6 Design for Gender- and Age-Inclusive Digital Trust

Female respondents exhibit lower trust ($M = 3.19$) than male respondents ($M = 3.38$), and those above 60 report the lowest trust of all age groups ($M = 2.80$). These gaps require gender- and age-responsive platform design: user interface testing with female and older participants, digital literacy programmes addressing their specific concerns, and disaggregated performance data. Nigeria's SDG 5 and 10 commitments provide the accountability framework.

7. Conclusion

This paper has argued, on the basis of primary survey data from 215 Nigerian citizens and multiple OLS regression analysis, that Nigeria's e-government programme is being structurally undermined by trust deficits and platform instability. With fewer than half trusting the security of their online submissions, nearly half experiencing platforms that frequently crash, and complaint resolution performing below the scale midpoint, the evidence documents a profound gap between digital governance ambitions and citizens' digital realities.

The regression evidence establishes that overall efficiency, trust in security, user-friendliness, and complaint resolution are the independent predictors of citizen satisfaction ($\text{Adj. } R^2 = 0.432$). Trust is predominantly a function of perceived efficiency and platform stability — confirming that reliability is the primary vehicle through which government can build security confidence. Satisfaction, in turn, is the sole gateway to the recommendation behaviour that drives viral e-government adoption.

These are not merely technical failures but symptoms of deeper innovation system pathologies: underfunded infrastructure, corruption that migrates across channels, weak accountability mechanisms, and the persistent gap between policy formulation and implementation. Afrobarometer Round 10 (2024) confirms the national scale: 92.9% of Nigerian adults rated government performance on economic management as poor, 88.2% on corruption control, 54.1% disagreed that officials explain their actions, and 43.9% that government listens to citizens. E-government platforms are being built on an institutional foundation that is cracked at its core.

The paradox of optimism — 84.4% believing services will improve — represents a window of opportunity, not a permanent reprieve. Policymakers must convert this latent goodwill into sustained citizen engagement through visible, measurable service quality improvements. The trust-reliability feedback loop identified here is a structural risk for any African e-government programme that prioritises platform launch over reliability, and policy announcement over accountability.

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